

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SELECTIVE NEPOTISM

You can't preach against it and also practise it—at least not too visibly. The nuke in the BJP's rhetorical armoury is its stand against dynasty. They only have to so much as mention it, and then sit back and watch the stock make money. What, then, do you do about people like Pankaj Singh? The 44-year-old son of Union defence minister Rajnath Singh won Gautam Buddh Nagar a second time by a margin of 175,000 votes, among the steepest in UP. Naturally, his name was recommended for Yogi Adityanath's new cabinet. But the central leadership nixed the idea: the 'no dynasty' slogan can't be harmed right now. It's okay if it's somewhere less noticeable, though. In neighbouring Uttarakhand, Saurabh Bahuguna, son of ex-CM Vijay Bahuguna, is in the cabinet. And Ritu Khanduri Bhushan, daughter of former CM B.C. Khanduri, is the speaker. Maybe Pankaj can think of relocating to the hills.

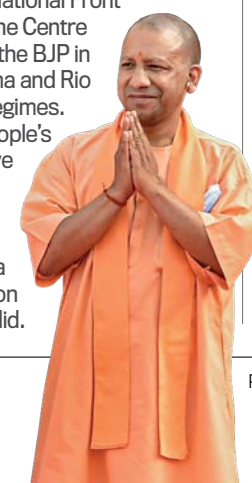


The Future Speaks

Ramesh Tawadkar, a senior figure among the BJP's Goa new flock of MLAs, was initially unwilling to accept the post of assembly speaker. He considered it a bad omen as former speakers Rajesh Patnekar and Rajendra Arlekar had lost the election when they were presiding over the assembly (in 2022 and 2017, respectively). But CM Pramod Sawant, an ex-speaker himself, managed to convince Tawadkar. Also, Arlekar is the governor of Himachal Pradesh now. Tawadkar is finally all set to become Goa's first ST speaker.

A NORTHEAST BOYCOTT?

It was fairly conspicuous. Uttar Pradesh CM **Yogi Adityanath** had invited all NDA chief ministers to his swearing-in and almost all of them graced the occasion except for three notable absentees—Meghalaya's Conrad K. Sangma, Zoramthanga of Mizoram and Nagaland's Neiphiu Rio. Zoramthanga's Mizo National Front is part of the NDA at the Centre but has no truck with the BJP in the state. Both Sangma and Rio run BJP-dependent regimes. Sangma's National People's Party and the BJP have had it rough since the two parted ways in Manipur. In fact, Sangma and Zoramthanga didn't even wish Yogi on the day—as even Rio did.



PTI

–Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Kiran D. Tare and Amarnath K. Menon



GANDHIAN MODI

Eyebrows were raised when **Sumitra Gandhi-Kulkarni**, grand-daughter of Mahatma Gandhi, inaugurated a portal, modistory.in, dedicated to 'untold stories' of PM Narendra Modi, on March 28. Launched by his admirers, the portal showcases narratives by all manner of figures, from politicians to sportspersons like Neeraj Chopra. The 81-year-old Gandhi-Kulkarni has known Modi since his younger days. Being graced by a Gandhi would perchance make the portal look a bit more universal in its appeal, and less of a party campaign artefact.

An Andhra Thaali



When he became chief minister in mid-2019, **Y.S. Jaganmohan Reddy** ensured all district bigwigs and influential caste cohorts found a place in his cabinet. He had then promised to recast the team halfway through the term. It did not happen in December. Nor, as speculated, on New Year day 2022. Meanwhile, post-reorganisation, the number of districts are up from 13 to 26. With a lengthening list of claimants, Jagan has a task on his hands. Sources say a reconstructed team could be announced on April 11, deemed auspicious as it's Chaitra Suddha Dasami.